



RENTAL PROPERTY MANAGER

User Manual



Version 2.0 · July 2026

A complete walkthrough of every screen and feature — covering both the Standalone edition (one person, one computer) and the Network edition (a shared team install).

Standalone

One person, one computer

Network

Shared team install

Free to Use

See LICENSE

■ Standalone-only content

■ Network-only content

Sections and boxes marked this way apply only to that edition. Everything else applies to both.

*For installation and setup instead, see the separate **Install Guide**. This manual picks up once the app is already running.*

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1. Getting Started

Rental Property Manager tracks income and expenses across every property you own. The property switcher in the top bar filters the Dashboard, Transactions, and reports to one property at a time, or to “All Properties” for a combined view. Everything else in this manual assumes you've picked a property (or “All Properties”) from that dropdown first.

The top navigation is organized so every major feature has its own tab — Dashboard, Transactions, Recurring, Mileage, Tenants, Documents, Import, Compare, Tax Documents, Properties, and Settings. Nothing important is buried inside another screen; if you're looking for a feature, check the tab bar first.

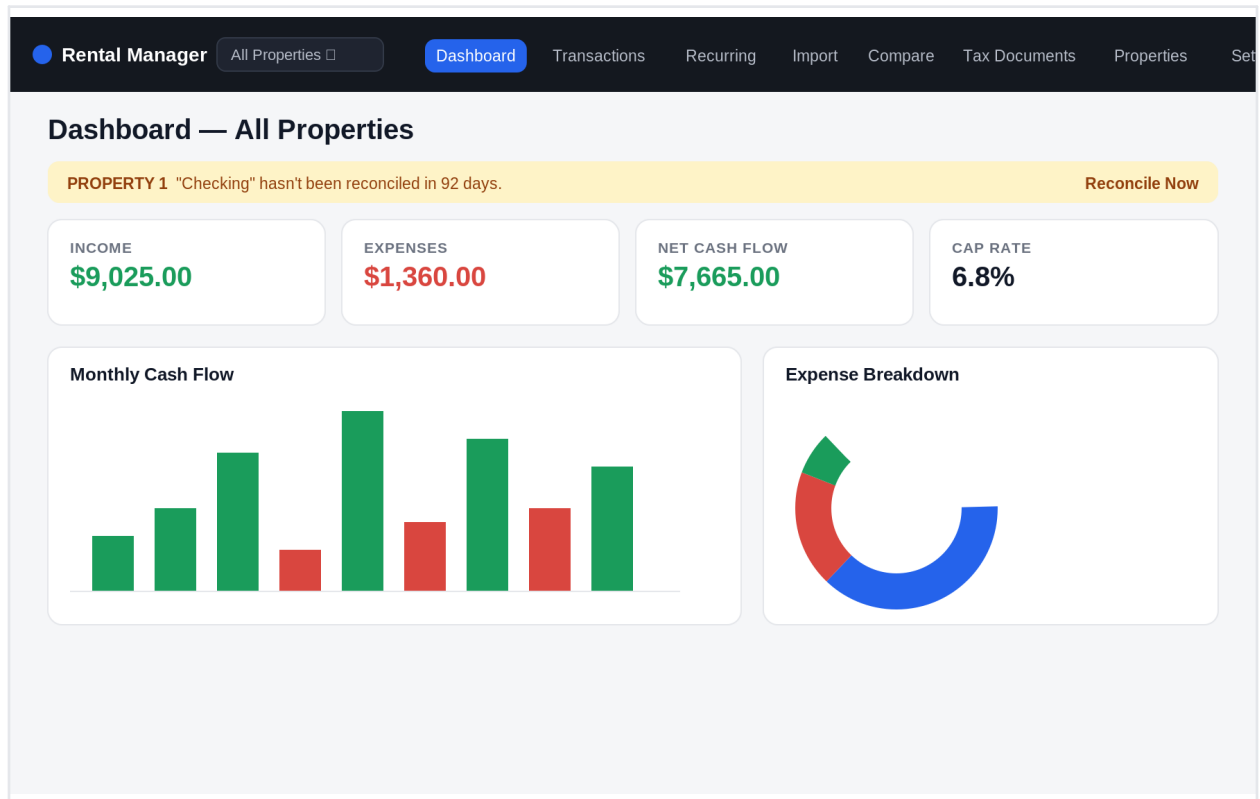
STANDALONE EDITION

There's no login. The first time the app runs, a one-time setup screen asks how you want to use it — choose “Just me on this computer.” Your data lives in a single local SQLite file (data/rental_manager.db, or %LocalAppData%\RentalManager\data\rental_manager.db if installed via the .exe installer). Nothing leaves this computer. Back that file up periodically, or use Settings → Backup & Restore (Section 15).

NETWORK EDITION

The first time the app runs on the shared machine, the setup screen asks for your PostgreSQL connection details and creates the first Admin account. After that, everyone who opens the app in their browser sees a login screen — sign in with the username and password an Admin created for you (Settings → Users, Admin only). Every transaction records who entered it. Three roles control what you can do:

- **Admin** — everything an Editor can do, plus managing user accounts and business branding.
- **Editor** — full read/write on properties, transactions, categories, and imports.
- **Viewer** — can see everything and export reports, but can't add, edit, delete, or import anything.



The Dashboard is the default screen — a quick financial snapshot for whichever property (or all of them) is selected above.

2. Business Profile & Branding

Go to **Settings** → **Business Profile** and add your business name, address, phone, email, website, and tax ID. Upload a logo (PNG, JPG, BMP, or GIF) and it's automatically resized into the two sizes the app needs — a compact version for the header, a larger one for report letterheads — so one upload works everywhere. Once set, your business name and logo replace the generic “Rental Manager” branding in the app and appear as a letterhead on every PDF and Excel export.

Also in Settings: custom income/expense/accent colors, a currency symbol, a fiscal year start month (so “This Year” / “YTD” / “Last Year” quick ranges adjust automatically if your books don't run on a calendar year), and a report footer line that prints at the bottom of every export.

The **Categories** box lets you add your own income/expense categories, retag any category to a Schedule E line, and delete ones you don't use. If you accidentally delete one of the built-in categories, click **Restore Default Categories** to add back only the ones that are missing — it never duplicates a category you still have or touches anything you've added yourself.

3. Properties

Click **+ Add Property** and type a name — the property is created automatically as soon as you move out of the Name field (you'll see a small “Saved” hint), so you can immediately start adding bank accounts and units without a separate save step. All the Save / Cancel / Archive buttons live in a footer at the bottom of the property window for anything else you change (address, purchase price, mortgage details, notes), and the property's name stays pinned at the top of the window so it's always clear which property you're editing.

Edit Property — 123 Main St

Name: 123 Main St Address: 123 Main St, Springfield

Bank Accounts

Checking · ****1234	Balance: \$4,210.55	Reconcile
Savings · ****5678	Balance: \$1,050.00	Reconcile

Tenants & Leases

Jane Doe · Unit 2 · \$1,500/mo · 01/01/26 → 12/31/26

Mileage

07/10/26 · Inspect unit · 42 mi @ \$0.76/mi — \$31.92

Documents

□ lease-2026.pdf · lease · Expires 12/31/26

Cancel Save

A property's edit window covers its core details, bank accounts, and units. Tenants, Mileage, and Documents each have their own top-level tab (Sections 6, 7, and 9).

- **Bank accounts** — add one or more per property (checking, savings, etc.), each with its own always-visible starting balance field and a computed running balance. Each account has its own bold, blue **Reconcile** button (Section 11).
- **Units** — for multi-unit properties, name each unit so transactions and the dashboard can optionally break out income/expenses per unit. “Copy From” lets you clone another property’s unit setup instead of typing it again.

Archiving a property (instead of deleting it) hides it from the property switcher and new-entry screens but keeps its history intact for past reports. Click **Show Archived** at the top of the Properties tab any time to see everything you've archived and click **Restore** to bring one back.

4. Transactions

Rental Manager All Properties ☐ Dashboard **Transactions** Recurring Import Compare Tax Documents Properties Set

Transactions

Reconcile Print + Add Transaction

From 01/01/2026 To 07/22/2026 Type: All Category: All

Income: **\$9,025.00** Expenses: **\$1,360.00** Balance: **\$7,665.00** 10 transactions

DATE	PAYEE	CATEGORY	ACCOUNT	AMOUNT
07/01/2026	Jane Doe	Rent Income	Checking	+\$1,500.00
07/05/2026	City Water Co	Utilities	Checking	-\$55.00
07/10/2026	Big Contractor LLC	Repairs & Maintenance	Checking	-\$2,500.00
07/15/2026	Jane Doe	Rent Income	Checking	+\$1,500.00
07/18/2026	Home Depot	Repairs & Maintenance	Checking	-\$142.30

Transactions list with filters and an always-visible totals bar.

+ Add Transaction opens a form for date, type (income/expense), category, property, unit, account, payee, amount, and notes, plus an optional receipt attachment. The list above it filters by date range, type, category, and unit, and a totals bar above the table always reflects the full filtered range — not just the page you're looking at. Use the rows-per-page selector (10/20/50/100) to control how much of the table shows at once.

Click **Reconcile** in the toolbar to jump straight to reconciling the account for whichever property is currently selected (Section 11) — handy when you've just finished entering a batch of transactions and want to check your work against a bank statement right away.

Amount vs. Distance: when you choose a category mapped to the Auto and Travel Schedule E line, an “Enter this trip as” choice appears — **Amount** or **Distance (miles)**. Amount works like any other expense. Distance instead has you type the miles driven; the app calculates the dollar amount for you from the current standard mileage rate (Settings → Tax Settings) and shows a live preview as you type. A Distance entry also logs the trip to the Mileage tab automatically and shows a small mileage badge next to it in the transactions list, so the trip and its dollar value always stay in sync — editing the linked entry later on the Mileage tab isn't possible for exactly that reason; edit the transaction here instead. Switching an existing mileage transaction back to a typed Amount removes that link and treats it as an ordinary travel expense going forward.

5. Recurring Transactions

Rental Manager

All Properties 

Dashboard

Transactions

Recurring

Import

Compare

Tax Documents

Properties

Settings

Recurring Transactions

+ Add Recurring

PROPERTY	PAYEE	AMOUNT	FREQUENCY	NEXT DUE	STATUS
123 Main St	City Water Co	\$55.00	Monthly	08/05/2026	Active
456 Oak Ave	First National Mortgage	\$1,120.00	Monthly	08/01/2026	Active
789 Pine Rd	Property Manager Co	\$310.00	Monthly	08/01/2026	Active
22 River Ct	Landscaping Service	\$85.00	Quarterly	10/01/2026	Inactive

Recurring transactions table.

For anything that repeats — rent, a mortgage payment, a subscription, a management fee — set it up once under the **Recurring** tab instead of re-entering it every period. Choose a property, category, payee, amount, account, and a frequency (weekly, monthly, quarterly, or yearly) with a start date and optional end date. The app generates the actual transaction automatically once its due date arrives — you'll see it appear the next time you open the Dashboard, Transactions, or Recurring tab, no background process required. Deleting a recurring rule stops future occurrences but never removes transactions it already generated.

6. Mileage Tracker

The **Mileage** tab lists every logged trip across one property or all of them, with an **+ Add Trip** button for logging a date, purpose, property, and miles driven directly — no need to open a property first. The deduction is calculated automatically at the IRS standard mileage rate in effect on that date and is snapshotted onto that trip — changing the rate later never rewrites the deduction on trips you've already logged, which matches how the IRS actually treats mid-year rate changes. Mileage deductions roll up automatically into that property's Tax Documents report (Section 13).

Trips created from a transaction's **Distance** option (Section 4) show a “Linked” status here instead of Edit/Delete buttons — edit those from the Transactions tab so the trip and its dollar amount never drift apart. Trips added directly on this tab are “Standalone” and can be edited or deleted here as usual.

A trip can optionally be tagged to one specific unit (e.g. driving out to fix a leak in Unit B) if the property has more than one — leave it as “none / whole property” for anything that isn't unit-specific, like a property-wide inspection. A linked trip (created from a transaction's Distance option) picks up whichever unit that transaction is tagged with automatically.

7. Tenants & Leases

The **Tenants** tab lists every tenant across one property or all of them. Click **+ Add Tenant** to record a name, assigned property and unit, contact info, lease start/end dates, monthly rent, and a security deposit. An expiring lease shows up as a Dashboard alert (Section 10) so renewals don't sneak up on you.

8. Import (CSV, Excel, or PDF)

Rental Manager All Properties ☐ Dashboard Transactions Recurring **Import** Compare Tax Documents Properties Set

Import Transactions

Map Your Columns

Date	Column A
Payee	Column B
Amount	Column D
Category	— not mapped —
Account	Column E

Import 24 Rows

Preview

☐ 22 rows will import - 2 rows unchecked - 3 duplicates skipped

☐ 07/01/26	Jane Doe	+\$1,500.00
☐ 07/05/26	City Water Co	-\$55.00
☐ Subtotal row	(skipped)	

Import screen with column mapping.

Export a transaction history from your bank as a CSV, Excel (.xlsx), or PDF statement and drop it into the **Import** tab. Digital PDFs (the normal kind you can select/copy text from) are read directly; a scanned or photographed statement falls back to OCR and the app tells you clearly when that happened, so you know

to double-check the extracted rows before importing. Map each of the app's fields (date, payee, amount, property, category, type, account, notes) to a column in your file — unmapped columns are simply left out, and the app tells you exactly which ones will be ignored. Uncheck individual rows to skip a stray header or subtotal line. Duplicate transactions are skipped automatically on re-import.

Auto-categorization rules (Settings → Import Auto-Categorization Rules): teach the importer that a payee (e.g. “HOME DEPOT”) should always land in a specific category, and every future import applies that rule automatically wherever the category can't otherwise be determined.

Importing a bank statement also automatically updates that account's reconciliation timer to the statement's date, since a statement is by definition an accurate balance as of that day (Section 11).

9. Property Documents

The **Documents** tab lists every stored file across one property or all of them. Click **+ Add Document** to upload a lease, insurance policy, inspection report, or any other file worth keeping alongside a property — no need to open that property first — tagged with a document type and an optional expiration date. A document within 60 days of expiring shows up as a Dashboard alert so it doesn't quietly lapse.

10. Dashboard, Alerts & Cap Rate

The Dashboard shows income, expenses, net cash flow, and transaction count for the selected date range, plus a monthly cash-flow chart and an expense-category breakdown. When one specific property is selected, two extra cards appear: **Cap Rate** and **Cash-on-Cash Return**, calculated from that property's purchase price, current value, and mortgage details (entered on the property itself).

A yellow alert bar above the charts flags things worth a look: a bank account that hasn't been reconciled in a while (with a one-click **Reconcile Now** link — Section 11), a property with no transactions logged this month, a lease expiring soon, or a document expiring soon.

11. Reconciliation

Reconcile Account	
123 Main St — Checking	
Statement Date	07/22/2026
Statement Balance (from your bank)	4,210.55
App-Computed Balance	\$4,210.55
Statement Balance	\$4,210.55
Discrepancy	\$0.00 — matches!
Close	

Reconcile window comparing computed and statement balances.

Reconciling checks the app's computed balance for one bank account against your actual bank statement for a given date. Open a property, find the account, and click the bold blue **Reconcile** button — or use the Reconcile button on the Transactions page, or a “Reconcile Now” link on a Dashboard alert, both of which take you straight there. Enter the statement date and the balance shown on your bank statement; the app shows you its own computed balance, the statement balance, and the discrepancy between them. If they don't match, you can add a one-line adjustment transaction to bring the books in line (e.g. a bank fee you hadn't entered yet) — the adjustment is clearly marked as one, and reconciliation history is kept per account so the Dashboard alert knows how long it's been since the last check.

12. Compare Properties

The **Compare** tab puts any subset of your properties side by side — income, expenses, net cash flow, cap rate, and cash-on-cash return — with checkboxes to pick exactly which ones to include, not just all-at-once.

13. Tax Documents

Rental Manager	All Properties ▾	Dashboard	Transactions	Recurring	Import	Compare	Tax Documents	Properties	Set
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Tax Documents — Tax Year 2026

Schedule E — 123 Main St

Rents Received	\$18,000.00
Repairs	\$2,940.00
Auto & Travel (incl. mileage)	\$318.50
Mortgage Interest	\$5,120.00
Net Income	\$9,621.50

Export PDF

Vendor / 1099 Report

PAYEE	TOTAL PAID
Big Contractor LLC	\$2,500.00
Meets 1099 threshold	
Home Depot	\$142.30

Tax Documents report with Schedule E lines and vendor report.

The **Tax Documents** tab builds a Schedule E-organized report per property for a tax year you choose, including any mileage deduction logged for that property (Section 6), and exports to PDF. It also builds a **vendor report** — every payee paid as an expense during the year, flagging anyone who met the 1099-NEC/MISC reporting threshold (Settings → Tax Settings; the IRS threshold moved from \$600 to \$2,000 starting with 2026 payments, and this app defaults to the current figure). Attach receipts directly to individual transactions for backup during an audit.

In **Settings** → **Tax Settings**, the standard mileage rate has an **Update to Current Rate** button that looks up and applies the IRS rate in effect today with one click, so you don't have to track rate changes yourself. Trips you've already logged keep whatever rate was in effect when you entered them — updating the rate only affects trips logged from then on.

14. Global Search

The search box in the top bar looks across properties, transactions, and tenants at once — type a few letters of an address, a payee, or a tenant's name and click a result to jump straight there.

15. Backup & Restore

Settings → Backup & Restore offers two exports:

- **Business Profile Only** — your name, address, contact info, colors, and logo, with no properties or transactions. Useful for quickly re-applying your branding to a fresh install.
- **Full Backup (Profile + Data)** — everything: every property, transaction, category, and your business profile. Importing a full backup **replaces all current data** in whatever install you import it into, so it's meant for moving to a new computer or restoring after a problem, not merging two active installs.

STANDALONE EDITION

Backs up by copying the SQLite database file directly.

NETWORK EDITION

Backs up to a portable JSON format instead (since there's no single file to copy), and also includes user accounts. The two formats aren't interchangeable — each correctly rejects the other's file with a clear error rather than importing it incorrectly.

Danger Zone: at the bottom of Settings, two permanent reset options are available, both behind two confirmation steps (a warning screen, then typing DELETE in all caps) before anything is touched, and neither has an undo — back up first if there's any chance you'll want this data again. (In Network mode, both are Admin-only.)

- **Reset Data Only** — erases every property, transaction, tenant, mileage trip, document, recurring rule, and import rule, and resets categories and tax settings to their defaults. Your business profile, branding/logo, colors, and login are untouched — you stay signed in and never see the setup wizard.
- **Full Factory Reset** — erases all of the above plus your business profile, branding/logo, colors, and settings (in Network mode, and every user account), and sends the app back through the first-run setup wizard, exactly like a brand-new install.

Both buttons are locked (disabled, with an explanation) until you've exported a **Full Backup** within the last 5 days — the app checks this automatically and shows the days-since-last-backup right above the two buttons. This exists so a reset is never the only copy of your data that gets destroyed. If you haven't backed up recently, click **Export Full Backup** above first, then come back down to Danger Zone.

16. Access Password / Managing Users

STANDALONE EDITION

Standalone mode normally has no login at all — whoever opens the app on this computer sees everything. If this computer is shared, or you'd rather it not open straight to your financial data, **Settings** → **Access Password** lets you turn on a single shared password (no username, just one password for the whole app). Once set, the app shows a lock screen at startup — and any time after that, the **Lock Now** button in the top bar re-locks it immediately without closing the app.

Changing or turning off the access password always asks for the current password first, even though you're already past the lock screen to be looking at Settings at all — a small safeguard in case someone finds an already-open browser tab left unattended.

The first time you turn the password on, you'll also choose **3 security questions** and answer all of them — this is the recovery path if the password is ever forgotten (see Section 17). You can update the questions later from the same Settings box.

Underneath the security questions is an optional **lockout** setting: pick a number of consecutive wrong guesses (password or security answers) that locks the app out for 15 minutes. It's blank/off by default — turn it on if you're worried about someone sitting there guessing.

NETWORK EDITION

Admins manage accounts under **Settings** → **Users** — add a username, email, and role (Admin, Editor, or Viewer), and share the initial password with that person directly (there's no self-signup). Deactivating a user keeps their historical transactions attributed to them but blocks further logins.

17. Forgot a Password?

NETWORK EDITION

If one Admin forgets their password, any *other* Admin can fix it in two clicks: **Settings** → **Users**, edit that person, and type a new password for them — no need for anything below.

Only if every Admin account is locked out at once (or there's only ever been one), a technical operator can run `reset_admin_password.py`, included alongside the app. It connects directly to the Postgres database this install uses (the same one `config.json` already points at), lists the existing users, and lets you set a new password for one of them — completely bypassing the login screen. It requires the same Python environment the app runs in and is meant for whoever set up the server, not day-to-day users.

STANDALONE EDITION

On the lock screen, click **Forgot password?** and answer any **one** of your 3 security questions correctly — you'll immediately be able to set a brand new password, no email or support desk involved.

If you've forgotten the password **and** all 3 security answers, there's no further in-app recovery — the only way back in is direct access to the database file itself (a technically inclined person can open `rental_manager.db` with any SQLite tool and clear the `access_password_hash` row from the `settings` table; a small helper script, `reset_access_password.py`, is included alongside the app to do exactly that without needing to know SQL). This is why setting up the security questions when you first turn the password on matters — they're what keeps a forgotten password from becoming a real problem.

Printing & Exports

Dashboard, Transactions, and Compare each have a **Print** button that produces a clean printed page with your business letterhead, the full filtered data (not just what's visible on screen), and none of the app's navigation or buttons. Anywhere you see CSV/Excel/PDF export buttons, they export exactly what's currently on screen — the same filters and date range.

On Transactions, an attachment shows a bigger paperclip icon so it's easy to spot at a glance. Clicking it opens the receipt in a viewer window with its own **Print** button, instead of a new browser tab. Use **Print All Receipts** in the toolbar to print every receipt in the currently filtered list one after another.

*For installation instead of usage, see the separate **Install Guide**.*

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